

Ludo Sumbarta
The River Oath

1000 BC – 900 BC

Six walkers. Ten gates. One century.



Chapter 0

The Rope

~1000 BC · Vardhana reed gate

In the year the meadows still had no kingdom, Kael Gobu would later write, six people walked out of a reed town and called the grass a road.

He wrote it as an old man, in a hand that shook, on a scrap of beaten bark that smelled of smoke and ice. He did not write the century first. He wrote the rope.

The ten clans had met where the river bent and the mud held footprints for a single day. Elders too old to travel had spoken the River Oath in one breath: a party of six must walk to the Crystal Crown at Sphatika and win the Royal Game at every gate. If they won all ten, the clans would be one people and the land would have a name. If they failed, the clans would remain ten names arguing over water—and something older than argument, the force the children only half-heard in fireside stories, would keep peeling the world back to wilderness.

They did not call that force Takshak at the rope. They called it the King of Serpents, and they said he could not enter a game once the die had been cast and all six stood in the court. They said he could do everything else.

The reed gate at Vardhana was two posts and a wet line of hemp. Beyond it the meadow went on as if no one had ever decided anything. Mist clung to the river reeds. A heron stood on one leg and watched them as if they were a joke the water had told.

Baby Dufaan stood with a wooden die in both palms. The die was older than the town. Its pips had been burned in with a nail, and when Baby turned it the marks looked like small wounds that had healed wrong.

Mani Dufaan was already on the far side of the rope.

"If you wait for a number," she said, "the grass grows over your feet."

Kael counted the faces under the reed roofs. His own heart beat like a second die. Taro Domizon had a copper pin in his teeth and swore it would become a tool before it became a weapon. Maya Mersace had something in her sleeve she had not shown anyone—not even Mani, who usually knew everything about everyone. Borin Gubatti had the packs, and the packs were enough for a season if they did not meet winter too soon.

They did not know they were founding Sumbarta. They knew only the sentence, and the weight of ten clans watching from the bank.

Baby shook the die. It came up six.

Kael felt the number land in his chest like a command. Six pips. Six walkers. Not five, not seven. The oath had teeth.

"Together," he said.

Mani did not wait. She walked. The hemp line brushed her shoulder and left a dark wet stripe on her tunic, as if the gate had signed her.

Baby looked at Kael. Kael looked at the others. Taro spat the pin into his palm and pocketed it. Maya's eyes were on the far meadow, unreadable. Borin hitched the straps and followed Mani.

Baby crossed last, die still warm, and when his foot touched grass on the far side he understood—without words—that the road had begun counting them.

Behind them, someone on the bank struck a reed drum once. Not celebration. Witness.

Ahead, there was only path, and the rumor of ten cities, and a crown of crystal no one in Vardhana had seen.

Kael would write, decades later, that the rope was the true first gate. Everything after was only a longer way of asking whether six could stay six.

Mani was already far ahead, calling back that the grass was shorter here and the snakes, if there were snakes, had not yet voted.

Baby ran to catch her.

At the river, before the rope, an elder had pressed the die into Baby's hands and said, "Wooden remembers. Glass forgets. Iron lies." Baby did not know then that he would carry the same wood to crystal.

Taro spat the copper pin into his palm once more on the meadow side and said, "First tool of the walk." Maya finally showed what hid in her sleeve: not a weapon, a strip of bark already inscribed with the ten clan marks, as if she had known they would need reminding.

Borin adjusted the packs so the weight sat on his hips, not his heart. "Six straps," he said. "Six lives."

Kael looked at the horizon. No crown visible. Only the obligation to try.

The ten clan marks on Maya's bark strip caught the light: ten doors, ten games, one walk. If they failed at the ninth gate, the elders had said, Takshak would not burn them in a day. He would unweave them slowly—fields to reed, names to wind. Victory was not glory. It was weather you negotiated.

Baby tucked the die into a pouch at his belt. Six pips facing out, because Mani had already moved and superstition needed help.

The century began.



Chapter 1

Meadow Gateway

Vardhana · Amber · First Royal Game

Vardhana was reed homes and a timber gate and amber in the riverbank that looked like trapped sunlight. The clan called the place Meadow Gateway, as if a meadow could be a door. The first road was not stone. It was a path worn by goats and children, and in the third week it opened under Mani's heel.

The pit was a mouth in the grass. She went in to the shoulder before Borin got a strap around her. Baby saw the white of her eyes and understood, for the first time, that the land had opinions.

They pulled her out. Maya pressed a palm-sized board of woven reed against Mani's ribs—a shield the old women had given them at the gate, one life, they said, one only. Mani pushed it away.

"Save it for someone who falls by accident," she said. "I looked."

Kael marked the pit with three stones so the next traveler would see it. There would be no next traveler for years, but habit is how people become

a clan.

There was a snake in the same grass two days later, thick as Borin's forearm, painted like wet bronze. It did not bite. It waited on the path as if the path belonged to it, and when Taro stepped wide the snake took the space he had left and Baby's token—a river stone they used for the walking-game—slid back toward the timber gate as if an invisible hand had shoved it.

Baby's throat closed. He had heard Takshak's name whispered at the river. He did not say it now. The snake's eyes were old in a way animals should not be old.

Kael picked the stone up and put it in Baby's hand.

"The game and the road are the same thing," he said. "If we forget that, we will win nothing."

They mined amber where the river undercut the bank. Three deposits, because the gate-keepers would not open the board for less. Baby's nails went yellow. Taro invented a scoop from a gourd and a stick, and for a week he was happier than the amber. Mani hauled baskets until her shoulders bled. Borin carried double when no one asked. Maya disappeared at dusk and returned with knowledge she did not share—where the bank was soft, which roots would hold a rope, which elder would speak if spoken to softly.

The royal key they found was wood and river-stone, hung on a thong in a shrine no taller than Borin's knee. The priest was a girl with mud on her shins.

"You may play," she said, "when all of you have arrived. Not the bravest. All."

So they waited for Taro, who had gone back for his scoop, and for Maya, who had gone nowhere she would name. When the six stood together, the timber gate opened onto a packed-earth court painted with triangles and circles—the Royal Game, older than Vardhana's reeds.

Four sat: Baby and Mani, Kael and Borin. Taro and Maya stood witness, hands on each other's shoulders so the court would see a closed ring.

The clan of Vardhana played as if the meadow itself were watching. The die was the same die. On the second day Mani's last token was two squares from home and the Vardhana champion rolled a five with a smile that had been practicing all winter. Mani did not flinch. She moved Baby's token instead, sacrificing speed for a block, and on the third morning Baby's piece crossed the final line while Mani's still waited—a win that felt like trust rather than glory.

When it was done the girl-priest tied a reed bracelet on Baby's wrist.

"One city," she said. "The grass has noticed you."

They stayed through the first rains and the first dry. Children who had not been born when they arrived learned to say their names. Baby taught some of them to count pips. Taro fixed a loose timber in the gate and refused payment. Maya helped a woman birth a son and would not take a gift.

In the tenth year Kael said, "If we sleep here another season we will become a seventh house, and the road will close."

Mani was already packing.

At the rope—which was now a proper lintel with carvings—Baby looked back. The bronze snake had never returned, but sometimes the grass rippled with no wind, as if something long and patient were passing underneath, keeping pace.

They walked toward iron and rust.

Vardhana's girl-priest watched from the timber gate. She did not wave. She tied a fresh reed on the lintel for the next walkers who might come, though the oath said six only once per century. Superstition, again. Hope, again.

Baby touched the first river stone in his pouch—the one the bronze snake had sent backward—and felt the century unspool ahead like a path through tall grass.

Kael led with the bark strip Maya had shown at the rope, checking clan marks against stories told at campfires. Vardhana's amber still yellowed his nails when he gripped the char stick. The first chapter of the kingdom was already written in mud and bracelet fiber.

Mani did not look back. She never did. That was not cruelty. It was how she kept walking.

Mani led. The die rode in Baby's bag beside the first river stone.

In the years between the first win and the tenth-year departure, Vardhana changed around them. A second court was packed earth near the shrine. Travelers came to see the walkers who had beaten the meadow clan—not heroes, curiosities. Baby hated that and then got used to it.

The girl-priest grew into a woman with the same mud on her shins. She asked once if they feared Takshak on the road.

Mani answered, "We fear stopping."

Kael answered, "We fear becoming seven."

Baby answered, "I fear the pit."

The priest tied a second bracelet on his wrist for luck. Both rotted eventually. The habit of tying did not.

One city. Nine to go.



Chapter 2

Iron Dune Quarry

Ayaskara · Black iron · The rust monster

Ayaskara was not a town. It was a caravan camp around a wound in the dunes, where men pulled iron out of the earth as if the earth were a hide. The clan called it Iron Dune Quarry. Smoke rose day and night. The air tasted of filings. There was no snake in the grass. There was something worse.

They arrived in a year when the foreman had lost three men to a collapse. He looked at the six as if they were either salvation or extra mouths.

"We don't play games for strangers," he said.

Kael showed the reed bracelet on Baby's wrist, faded but still tied. The foreman's eyes narrowed.

"The meadow sent you. The dunes will test you."

The test came at dusk on a wind that tasted of rust. Baby would never find a better word for what followed. It was the quarry's own hunger given shoulders—a shape without a face that moved like a man and hit like a landslide. It drove Borin six paces back down the path they had climbed, and then six more, as if the road itself had spat him out. Maya's shield, unused since Vardhana, broke on it with a sound like a wet branch. The monster took the break as payment and was gone, leaving only iron dust swirling and a silence that felt like Takshak laughing without a mouth.

Borin sat in the dust and laughed once, which frightened Baby more than screaming would have.

"I thought I was the shield," he said.

Kael did not mine here. The camp already bled metal. Instead they worked the foreman's tally—ore weighed, slag sorted—until he owed them the right to search. They recovered a key of black iron from a box under the foreman's stone, cold enough to burn the tongue.

The Royal Game was scratched into a wagon floor with nail and charcoal. Quarry men played to wound: elbows on the rim, sharp jokes, tokens slammed. Kael played to end. He sacrificed his lead twice so Mani could enter the home row. On the final roll Taro held his breath so hard the copper pin left a mark on his lip. Borin blocked the foreman's last advance with a move so plain it looked like stupidity until it wasn't.

When they won, the foreman spat and then poured them water, which in Ayaskara was the same as a blessing.

They stayed long enough for Taro to learn the bellows and for Baby to stop dreaming of the pit every night—though he dreamed of the rust shape longer. Mani learned the dunes: which slopes sang before they slid, where mirage water lied. Maya learned who stole whose ore and spoke to a thief in a language Baby did not know; the thief returned a pouch the next day and would not meet Maya's eyes.

In the last year a boy from the camp asked to walk with them. He had clever hands and a scar across his knuckles.

Kael said no.

"The oath is six," he said. "If we become an army, we become a different story."

The boy watched them leave. Baby looked back until the camp was only a stain on the iron.

On the dune's lip, Kael wrote on bark for the first time—a single line: *The road can throw you back six and six. Count anyway.*

Mani took the first step down the far slope.

The boy from the camp brought them flatbread on the last morning—no words, only food. Baby left his second-best scoop for him, gourd and stick, the kind of gift that means *I see you* without breaking the oath.

At night, before the dunes, they practiced the Royal Game on packed sand until the stars wheeled. Mani accused Kael of counting too loudly. Taro carved temporary tokens from slag. Maya won three times and refused to boast.

Kael dreamed of the rust shape and woke with the word *Takshak* on his tongue. He did not speak it aloud. The dunes were listening.

On the wagon-board, Baby learned that quarry rules allowed a player to forfeit a turn to "cool the iron"—a superstition that became strategy when Kael used two forfeits in a row to force the foreman's champion to overcommit. Mani knocked her knee against the table once, accidentally on purpose, rattling the die. The foreman glared. Maya smiled like innocence.

When victory came, the camp's women brought sour tea that stripped the rust taste from their mouths. An old digger touched Baby's forehead with a blackened thumb. "You walked in hungry country," he said. "Walk out before it walks into you."

They traded a wedge of amber for dried meat and iron nails. Taro pocketed nails as if they were dice. Everything was a tool if you loved it

enough.

Two cities behind them. Eight ahead.

Baby counted pips on the wagon-board until he could dream them. Mani counted steps. Taro counted nails. Maya counted faces that owed favors. Borin counted nothing aloud; his silence was its own arithmetic.

At the dune's edge, the foreman shouted after them: "If the serpent king comes, tell him the quarry paid in blood already!" Kael raised a hand—acknowledgment, not agreement—and did not look back.



Chapter 3

Monsoon Serpent Trail

Varshana · Sunstone · Debt of the shrine

Varshana was rain.

A shrine leaned over an untamed trail, and the trail was called Monsoon Serpent Trail because the water made a snake of every path. They came in the season when the causeways were the only ground, raised stones slick as fish. Sky and hill blurred. Thunder walked the ridges without hurry.

Sunstone—pale, hot even in the wet—had to be taken from three pockets in the hill. The work was miserable and holy. Baby's fingers blistered. Borin held the rope while Mani swung on a loop of vine into the second pocket, cursing the rain with affection.

Taro found a tunnel the shrine-keepers used in flood, a brown throat through the slope. It saved them days. It also put them in the shrine's debt.

The serpent of Varshana was not a beast in the grass. It was a god with a priest who smiled with all his teeth and said, "You stole our dark. Now

win our board, or the rain will keep you."

Kael asked what dark they had stolen.

"The tunnel," the priest said. "Dark is a coin here. You spent it without paying."

Maya stepped forward. "We will pay at the board."

They played under a roof that leaked in four places. Water drummed. Maya sat this time, and Taro, and Baby, and Kael. Mani and Borin witnessed, drenched but steady.

The priest's champion was a woman who never looked at the die, only at the pieces, as if she could hear them slide. She played like rainfall—patient, overlapping, wearing grooves in their patience. Baby's token climbed a ladder of luck and was bitten by a carved serpent on square seventeen, sent back to the trail's mouth on the board. He wanted to cry. Mani squeezed his shoulder once, hard enough to hurt, kind enough to stay.

On the second night Taro traded a sunstone chip for position—not cheating, a rule of Varshana Kael had confirmed—and opened a path. Maya moved as if she had already seen the end. When Baby's last token reached the home triangle the priest laughed and the laugh was not kind.

"The god permits a kingdom," he said, "that remembers it was permitted."

They pressed sunstone into the shrine's palm. The rain did not stop, but it stopped *following* them—a subtle change only Maya named.

They left Varshana with sunstone in a wrap and rain in their clothes that never quite dried. Baby was no longer a child. He noticed this when he stopped asking Mani if they were lost.

On the trail out he saw a bronze scale caught in a root, too large for any fish. He did not pick it up. He told Kael. Kael wrote: *Takshak's touch is a scale, a pit, a hop backward. He does not sit at the board.*

Three cities. Seven gates remaining.

Between rains they slept in the shrine's lean-to, listening to water count the hours. Baby learned to read the board by sound—the slide of shell on wet wood, the sigh when a token was eaten by a painted serpent square. Taro patched their sandals with vine. Borin told stories of Vardhana's pit until Mani threw a sunstone chip at him and he grinned.

The priest visited once without his smile. "The King of Serpents does not love walkers," he said, as if confessing. "He loves repeaters. Do not walk the same mistake twice."

They honored that by arguing every evening about tomorrow's route—never the same argument twice, Mani said, which was almost true.

On the morning they left, the champion woman nodded to Baby. No praise. Recognition.

The sunstone they carried was wrapped in oiled cloth that never dried. It warmed Baby's chest like a second heart. Borin carried the heaviest wrap without being asked.

Varshana's children ran beside them to the causeway edge, splashing, daring the serpent-trail to take them. Mani ran with them for a hundred paces, laughing, then stopped as if a wall had appeared. Duty again. Road again.

Kael noted in bark the priest's warning about repeaters. He underlined it twice.

The canopy waited, green and high.

Rain followed them two days out, not punishing, only persistent—the shrine's last joke. Taro sang marching songs badly. Baby discovered he could predict Mani's mood by how she tied her sash. Kael discovered he could not predict Maya at all, which was either safety or danger.

They crossed a stream where ten flat stones made a natural board. Baby set tokens and taught Taro a opening move Vardhana children used. "The meadow opens wide," he said. It felt like prayer.



Chapter 4

Emerald Canopy

Haritavana · Emerald · The swaying court

Haritavana took the road off the ground.

The village lived in the canopy, houses lashed to living trunks, bridges of rope that spoke when the wind moved—a low moan the clan said was the trees remembering storms. Emerald lay in the moss, three veins they had to cut without killing the trees, because the clan would not open a gate for a wound.

Taro's happiest years were these. He learned the knots. He made a bridge that did not speak, and the old women of the canopy touched it as if it were a child. Baby learned to sleep with one hand on a rope. Kael mapped platforms in charcoal on bark, numbering safe routes for elders who would come after—an act of faith that Sumbarta would exist.

There was no monster. There was no pit. There was height, and trust, and Baby's first true fear, which was not of falling but of watching someone else fall. Mani ran the ropes as if they were meadow. Borin went

on his knees, muttering apologies to the trees. Maya crossed at night, because she said the dark made the drop honest.

Once, a rope snapped under a load of moss-wrapped emerald. Taro caught the line with a hook he had forged in Ayaskara. The bundle swung. No one died. Everyone shook for an hour.

The Royal Game was played on a platform that swayed. The key was a green stone on a cord of vine. Tokens were seeds and shell. A wrong move did not only lose ground—it made the platform tilt, and the clan watched from above like birds.

They won in a dusk like underwater light. The final roll was a two; Baby moved with hands steadier than his voice. The clan of the Emerald Canopy fed them fruit that stained their mouths, and for a time the six believed the century would be kind.

It was not.

Kael wrote little during the happy years—only dates, only names of children who learned the Royal Game in the canopy and thought the whole world was rope and trust. He would catch up later, on colder stone.

When they descended, the meadow world felt too flat.

Haritavana's parting gift was a bridge-knot diagram burned onto a leaf. Taro studied it all the way down, muttering. "Silver trees next," he guessed. Maya neither confirmed nor denied.

Baby's fear of watching others fall never left, but it became a skill: he learned to spot loose lashings, to call "hold" before disaster. The canopy clan called him *eyes*. He preferred his name.

The emerald toll left their packs heavier and their shoulders stronger. The Royal Game platform swayed one last time in memory when wind touched the trunks below. Borin kissed the ground and meant it as a joke and as prayer.

Mani looked south toward smoke and silver.

Four cities behind them.

Baby touched the reed bracelet, almost gone to fiber, and the first river stone in his pouch.

Years in the canopy changed their bodies. Mani's ankles hardened. Kael's shoulders broadened from hauling emerald in moss slings. Baby grew tall enough that strangers stopped calling him Baby; Mani still did, which kept him young and annoyed.

The clan taught them a rule: on the swaying court, you may not touch the rim with both hands. One hand for balance, one for mercy. Borin played with one hand behind his back until the champion laughed and conceded a teaching game.

They celebrated a wedding on the platform—two canopy youths who wanted the gods to witness on ground that moved. After, the whole village played an open Royal Game until moonrise. The six sat together and watched, not playing, feeling for the first time like elders of something not yet named.

When emerald toll was paid, the old women pressed a single green chip into each palm. "For memory," they said. "Not for trade."

Maya strung hers on the same cord as the vine key, a quiet necklace no one commented on.

The forest had given them height. The next gate would teach them hiding.

On the lowest platform before descent, the canopy elders spoke a blessing that was also a warning: *What hides in silver may know your name.* Maya's face did not change. Baby noticed. He always noticed, now.

They left emerald chips at the roots of the bridge Taro had built—a toll of gratitude. Wind tested the knots one last time. The bridge held.



Chapter 5

Silver Lanterns

Rajatavana · Pale metal · A name not hers

Rajatavana hid.

Silver lanterns in a woodland hamlet that did not wish to be found. Paths turned back on themselves. Moss swallowed footprints. The clan lived as if names were a kind of smoke. Maya walked as if she had been born in that smoke. She would not say whether she had.

There was a mine in the roots, a clay pot packed with something that flashed and threw Baby back to the last stone they had called a checkpoint—a silver-marked tree. There was a pit under leaves. There was a snake that wore the lantern-light like jewelry, coiled once around a branch, gone when they looked again.

Maya used no shield. She used knowledge. She told Kael which path was a path and which was a throat. She negotiated with lantern-keepers in whispers. Baby followed and learned that leadership is sometimes walking behind someone who knows the dark.

In the fifth year of the silver shadows, a man of the hamlet offered them a shorter oath: stay, take lantern-right, forget the Crown.

"We could be safe," Taro said quietly, not to persuade—to test the words.

Kael refused. "Safe is a house. We are a walk."

The man smiled with Maya's kind of smile.

Two nights later Borin found the man at their packs with the royal key in his fist—a key of pale metal, already theirs, already stolen back. Borin did not hit him. He sat on him until morning, immovable as a boulder the hamlet had learned to build around.

Maya spoke to the man in a voice Baby had not heard, low and final. In the morning the man was gone and Maya's sleeve was empty.

"What did you give him?" Baby asked.

"A name," she said. "Not mine."

They played the Royal Game in a hall without windows. Lanterns hung from chains; their light made the board look like a lake. The hamlet's champion was old and slow and cruel in small ways—extra roll, "forgotten" rule, a toe on the rim. Kael cited the River Oath. The old one yielded with a grunt that meant respect.

They won, and the win felt like a secret the forest would keep or would not. When they left, Baby looked for Maya's face in every lantern and found it, and also did not.

Taro marked a tree with a silver nail—his own invention, a cousin to the copper pin. Mani said they were collecting metals the way the gates collected years.

Five cities. The peaks waited, breathing gold.

In the hamlet's last week, Baby walked the lantern paths alone and practiced remembering turns without marking bark—memory as survival. He got lost once, found himself by following the smell of fish oil, and laughed at his own fear.

Maya taught him a trick: when a path forks, choose the one that sounds quieter. "Noise is bait," she said. He asked who taught her. She said, "The smoke."

In the windowless hall, the board was inlaid with silver wire so fine it looked like frozen spiderwork. Rules appeared as they played—lantern-right meant a witness could swap one roll; smoke-right meant a witness could cancel a swap. Taro witnessed for Maya; Mani for Baby. The game became a duel of permissions, not pieces.

Baby rolled a one when he needed a six. Maya traded him her next turn without looking at him, a sisterhood of dice. On the final sequence Kael held three tokens in the outer ring while the champion crowded the center—classic pressure. Kael fed him a false opening and walked a quiet token home on the rim, the long road, the walker’s road.

After the win, the hamlet did not feast. They dimmed lanterns one by one until only the board glowed. "Secrets keep better in low light," the old champion said.

Baby dreamed of silver snakes that night and woke to Maya already awake, staring at the treeline.

Rajatavana's lanterns used fish oil and a pinch of metal dust that made the flame whiter. Walking without them after years of silver light felt like blindness. They traveled by moon and habit until the peaks showed their teeth.

Maya did not speak of the man she had named away. She walked point more often. Kael did not ask. Borin checked the packs twice each camp, as if theft might grow back like moss.

The pale-metal key hung on Kael's neck, cold against skin. It chimed once on a root and everyone stopped, hand on token, until silence returned.

Kael wrote: *Rajatavana taught us that theft is not always of metal. Guard the names.*



Chapter 6

Goldforge Peaks

Suvarnagiri · Gold · The spent life

Suvarnagiri smoked.

The peaks breathed. A mining camp clung to the rock above seams of gold, and the clan of the highlands had already begun to speak of a kingdom that would not need ten clans, only one mine and one crown. Smoke stained the snow. Hammers rang like bad weather.

Taro's tunnel here was not a shrine-path. It was a hole the miners had abandoned because something in it ate sound. They used it anyway. Mani first, then the rest, the dark like a second rain. In that silence Baby heard his own blood, and behind it something else—a coil sliding over stone, not present but promised.

The monster of the Goldforge was not dusk and rust. It was the mine's own night. It drove Mani back down the gallery, hop after hop, as if a child were playing a cruel game with her body. Baby went after her with the last shield they had been given—a square of beaten gold no wider than

a hand, warm from a smith's palm.

The shield held. Mani stood, shaking. The gold square was a bent coin.

"One life," Kael said quietly. "We have spent it."

They took three measures of gold because the gate demanded three, and Kael made them swear not to keep a fourth. Maya weighed the ore with her eyes closed, as if listening for a lie in the metal.

The Royal Game was played on a stone table still warm from the forges. Heat rose through their elbows. The highland champion played like a man who had already won the century—confident, slow, smiling at their gray hair and torn packs. Borin, who sat that board, moved as if each token were a person he refused to leave in the dark. When he blocked the champion's last run, the smiths went silent.

Afterward the smiths wanted them to stay and be rich. Borin looked at the peaks and said, "If I stay I will become the monster's shape. I would rather be tired."

They went down toward grass. Mani's hands trembled for a week. Baby kept the bent gold in his pouch until Nilahima would ask for it.

Six cities behind them. Kael's bark was thick now, edges curled. He wrote the gold chapter twice and scratched one out, as if the first version boasted.

Takshak had not appeared with a crown of serpents. He did not need to. The hop-back game in the mine had been his handwriting.

The smiths taught Taro to beat gold thin enough to see breath through. He made a disk for Borin—useless armor, beautiful apology. Borin wore it under his shirt until the monster bent the real shield and the disk became only metal again.

At the stone table, heat made them dizzy. The champion offered wine. Kael refused for all of them. "Clear heads," he said. The champion shrugged. "Clear heads break slower."

Borin's winning move was to leave one token in danger so two of the champion's pieces had to chase it, opening a lane Mani had begged for in whispers. Afterward Borin could not lift his cup. Baby lifted it for him.

They descended through cloud. Mani sang a meadow song off-key. Taro tried to harmonize and failed beautifully.

Kael added a line: *Gold buys sleep. We are not for sale.*

Highland children watched the six descend and shouted questions: Had they seen the serpent king? Had they eaten gold? Baby shouted back, "We ate hunger!" and Mani cuffed him gently, smiling despite herself.

The sound-eating tunnel left Taro half-deaf for a week. He compensated by touching shoulders before speaking. The habit stayed.

Gold dust worked into their hair until they glittered like small false suns. At a stream they washed each other's scalps like siblings, like survivors.

Four gates left, then the Crown.

The highland champion shook Borin's hand after the loss—after their loss to him in games before, their win at the table—and said, "You play like a man who carries people in his pieces." Borin could not speak. He only nodded.

Smoke from Suvarnagiri followed them down the pass for days, a gray banner. Mani said it looked like a snake's breath. Kael said it looked like a forge remembering fire. Baby said it looked like home if home were dangerous.



Chapter 7

Copper Horizon

Tamrapatha · Copper · The map of grass

Tamrapatha was wind and copper and a horizon that did not end.

The village stood among totems green with weather, faces carved and repainted each spring. The clan guarded the southern way with stories more than spears. A snake lived in the dust and took Taro's token the week they arrived; he laughed, made another, and taught a child to carve the pips into soft wood.

They mined copper until their hands were the color of the totems. The work was honest and loud. Markets came on seasonal roads—a woman from the Kathua Plains traded salt; a rider from the Ravi Marches asked if Sumbarta was a place yet.

Kael said, "It is a walk that has not finished."

The rider squinted. "Walk long enough and it becomes a border."

"Or a people," Maya said.

Children of the clan learned the Royal Game as if it were speech. The six stayed long enough to see a generation of small players who had never known the reed gate. Baby felt the years then—not as numbers, as faces. Mani's hair had gray in it. Maya's had none, which Baby did not believe. Borin's knees spoke when he stood.

Taro raised a new post at the path's turning, not a god, only a mark: *the six passed here*. He carved the words shallow so rain would not erase them too quickly.

They won the gate-game on a board of baked clay. The key was copper, soft enough to bend, hard enough to open the south. The match lasted one afternoon and felt like a festival—drums, laughter, a stumble that became legend when Taro's token hopped home on a reckless four.

When they left, the totems had a new companion, Taro's mark, and the grassland looked like a map for the first time.

Baby walked beside Borin, matching his slower step without comment.

Seven cities. The moon-cliffs called.

Seasons turned on the savannah like pages. They helped plant millet. They mended totems after a storm. A child named Kesh learned Baby's name before she learned her grandmother's—an honor that made Baby quiet for a day.

The dust snake returned each year, always taking a token, never a finger. Taro made a game of it: carve, lose, carve again. "Takshak taxes the careless," he joked once. Kael did not smile. "Taxes the proud," he corrected. "Be careless on purpose if you must."

The baked-clay board cracked in the sun and was repaired with copper wire—a metaphor the clan loved. Their champion was a woman with laugh lines and ruthless endgame. Baby sat with her for the final match, his gray showing at the temples now. She rolled, he rolled, the crowd hummed. When his last token crossed, she bowed not to him but to the die.

Markets brought rumors: a king not yet born, a canal not yet dug, a serpent king who slept between centuries like a man between meals.

Mani bought salt and traded stories. Maya bought nothing and learned three new paths south.

Before departure, the clan painted their six faces on a totem—not gods, travelers. Taro cried and blamed the wind.

Copper key bent once in Baby's grip during a practice roll; he straightened it with a stone and thought of doors still unopened. The southern way stretched pale-green. Heat returned to their bones.

Kesh, the child who knew Baby's name, gave him a carved pip—one dot, the smallest number, the first step. He wore it on a cord beside the river stone.

Rider from the Ravi Marches rode alongside half a day, asking questions Kael answered in circles. At parting the rider said, "If Sumbarta is a walk, I hope it walks south." Kael said, "It walks where the gates are."

Kael wrote: *Tamrapatha asked if we were a place. We answered like walkers. Perhaps that is the only true answer.*

They stayed through a dry year when the totems cracked and Taro mixed copper dust into clay to repair faces. They stayed through a wet year when the dust snake's hollow flooded and became a pond children sailed leaf-boats on, pretending the boats were tokens heading home.

Baby taught Kesh the rule of six: not magic, discipline. Six walkers. Six sides on the die. Six paces back the monster had thrown Borin at Ayaskara—a number that still haunted Kael's dreams.

On the last night, the clan played an all-night Royal Game in their honor. Baby sat out, watching, letting his knees rest. Mani won three times and lost twice and did not care. Maya played once, won, and vanished before congratulations.

At dawn they took the southern track. Grass bent underfoot like a board waiting for pieces.



Chapter 8

Moonlit Cliffs

Chandrasaila · Moonstone · The bark record

Chandrasaila was quiet after so much horizon.

A shepherd outpost under moonlit cliffs. Moonstone in the rock, pale and cold. The clan counted stars more than coins. Fires were small. Songs were older than the words.

There was no pit waiting, no monster in the first month. The danger was looking backward. Baby caught Kael staring toward Vardhana's direction as if he could see the rope through a hundred years of walking.

Kael began the record there in earnest, sitting with his bark and a stick of char, writing the rope and the quarry and the rain.

"If we die in the ice," he told Baby, "someone must still know we were a people becoming."

Baby sat with him on the nights Mani walked the cliffs alone. She said the height cleared her head. Sometimes she did not return until the stars

had turned.

They mined moonstone with care, because the shepherds said the cliffs remembered greed. Chips were taken with prayers. One chip cut Maya's palm; she bled silver-pink in the moonlight and did not flinch.

The Royal Game was slow. The key was a white shard. Tokens clicked like teeth. The shepherd champion played for a draw until Borin forced a decision with a sacrifice Baby still did not fully understand. They won without joy and without shame, which Kael said was the correct temperature for a kingdom.

A shepherd-girl asked Baby if he had children. He said, "The road had them. I held some." It was a true answer and an empty one. She gave him milk anyway.

In the last winter of the peaks, Maya stood beside Kael's writing and said, "Leave my name out of the thefts. Put it in the wins."

Kael did both, which was his way of loving her.

Eight cities. Ice ahead. Borin's breath came harder on the climbs.

Baby counted the years without arithmetic—by how many times he had rewound the reed bracelet until it broke, by how many dies Taro had carved for teaching, by how many times the bronze snake had sent a stone backward.

Nine gates if you counted Sphatika. One life spent. One friend growing heavy in his bones.

Shepherds taught them to read weather in moonstone—clouds trapped in mineral, faint and blue. Maya could see tomorrow in a chip; she said it was guesswork and luck. Baby believed her anyway.

Mani's cliff walks became legend among the young. Once she brought back a kid goat lost on a ledge; the mother bleated her thanks. Borin could not make that climb anymore. He held the rope at the top and pretended not to mind.

The slow board at Chandrasaila punished haste. Games stretched across days. Witnesses changed shifts. Kael wrote between moves, documenting not only wins but pauses—who drank water, who slept, who stared at the moon as if negotiating with it.

In the third week of the final match, Baby offered a draw.

Shepherds brought milk and cliff-honey. Mani traded stories of iron and rain for their star-lore. Borin learned to name constellations he would never navigate, because learning was how he loved.

Moonstone chips clicked in a pouch like dice. Sometimes at night Baby shook the pouch and listened, pretending fate could be heard in mineral.

The white shard key cut Kael's thumb on the day of the win. He bled on the board and the shepherd champion said, "Good. Now it knows you." Superstition again, or religion. Hard to tell on the cliffs. The shepherd champion refused. "Kingdoms are not drawn," she said. "They are chosen." So he chose to win, one square at a time.

Maya's theft line in Kael's bark became a win line: *She bought us Rajatavana with a name. She bought us the cliffs with silence.*

They packed moonstone and char and bark enough for two more chapters, or twenty, if the ice allowed.

Ice rumors reached the cliffs before the cold did—stories of pits under snow, of sapphire that cut gloves, of a serpent black as a closed eye. Borin listened and rubbed his knees. "One more gate before the Crown," he said. "I can do one more."

Kael's bark volume grew heavy. He copied key passages onto a second strip in case the first was lost—Mani's idea, practical as a strap. Taro carved a case from cliff-wood to hold the record dry.

The shepherd-girl who gave Baby milk asked if Sumbarta would have a flag. He said, "We have a rope and a die." She looked disappointed. He added, "And ten cities that noticed us." She smiled then.

When they left Chandrasaila, moonstone chips rattled like promises. The cliffs watched them go without judgment.



Chapter 9

Frozen Frontier

Nilahima · Sapphire · Borin's last game

Nilahima was the cold that decides.

Cabins with warm mouths. A frozen frontier. Sapphire under ice the color of old bruises. The clan lived close and spoke little. Breath hung in the air like linen.

A tunnel ran under the ice-road, a brown memory of earth in a white country. They took it because the surface had begun to open—pits the snow hid until a foot found them. A snake, black against the drift, took a token and a day. Baby fell in a pit to the hip and Borin pulled him out with hands that had nothing left to spare.

They were elders in the way that mattered. Not always in years. In the way they checked the fire twice. In the way Mani no longer ran at every dark. In the way Taro's cheer had become a tool he used on purpose, like the copper pin, now a worn needle, that he still carried.

Sapphire came up in shards that cut gloves. Maya traded a moonstone chip for frost-salt. Kael negotiated gate-right with a woman whose face was half scar, half smile.

In the seventh year of the ice, Borin did not rise with the others.

He was breathing. He was not walking. The gentle giant looked at the packs as if they were a joke he finally understood.

"You will carry the gold of me," he said to Baby, "and leave the weight."

They did not leave him. They built a sledge of cabin-wood and copper nails Taro wept over while he hammered. Maya walked in front to find the firm ice. Kael counted their food into smaller and smaller honesties. Mani pulled until her palms opened. Baby pulled until he could not feel the rope.

Borin saw the cabins of the next fold, and the sapphire in the clan's doorway, and he saw the gate of Nilahima from the inside of the Royal Game—they sat him so he could move a token with a finger. The ice-clan played as if winning were a way to keep a man alive. On the last roll Borin whispered a number. Baby rolled it. The token advanced one square, then another, home.

Afterward Borin slept, and in the morning he did not.

They buried him under stones the color of the sky when it has no mercy. Baby put the bent gold shield in the cairn, the spent life, because Borin had been the other shield and there was no one to give it to.

Mani stood until her tears froze and then she broke them off her face with her thumb.

"Five," she said.

Kael said, "The oath was six. The walk is whoever is left. That is also a kind of together."

Baby did not forgive the sentence. He kept it.

Nine cities won. One crown left. Five walkers and a ghost at the rim.

Kael wrote Borin's name large, so the char would bite deep.

Ice years taught economy. Fewer words. Better soup. Taro repaired sledges for the clan in exchange for sapphire chips. Maya mapped safe tunnels with charcoal on bone. Mani hunted seal when hunting was allowed; when it was not, she did not argue.

The black snake on the drift appeared the day Baby fell in the pit. It took his token and left a scale like chipped obsidian. Baby kept the scale until Sphatika, then left it on Borin's cairn.

The gate-game with Borin's finger on the token was the longest hour of Baby's life. Each roll felt like a heartbeat counted aloud. When they won, the ice-clan did not cheer—they exhaled, a sound like wind through a crack.

Borin's grave faced south, toward grass he loved. Mani placed his share of packs on the stones. "Weight stays," she said.

Kael read the burial words from bark, voice steady until the last line, where it broke.

The sapphire toll was paid in chips that looked like frozen tears. The ice-clan gave them furs they could not refuse without insult. Mani cut hers to fit Baby's shoulders.

Tunnel under the ice-road became their last shortcut. Taro marked the entrance with copper nails in a row—six, always six.

When Borin could not walk, Baby told him stories of Vardhana's scoop and Tamrapatha's totem until Borin slept mid-sentence, smiling.

Somewhere under the ice, something serpent-long shifted—not attacking, only waiting for the last gate.

Five walked on. The sledge ropes left grooves in Baby's shoulders that never quite faded. Taro spoke to his copper needle as he walked, telling it about Borin, about nails, about bridges that did not speak.

Mani broke the ice at stream edges so the others could drink. Maya watched the facets of distant crystal peaks and said, "The Crown is close

enough to taste." It tasted like cold and completion.

Kael carried the bark and Borin's share of story. He would not let the sixth become a footnote.



Chapter 10

Crystal Crown

Sphatika · Ice-crystal · The River Oath sworn

Sphatika was not a city. It was a sacred enclosure of crystal, a crown that had been waiting since the river first taught the clans to swear. The air smelled of stone and endings. Walls rose in facets that caught the low sun and threw it back in colors no miner had named.

Ice-crystal in the rock—three deposits they cut with hands that remembered amber, a lifetime ago, when cutting had been a game.

There was a mine at the last approach, a flash underfoot that threw Kael back toward a marker of crystal stakes. He stood, bleeding at the mouth, and spat red on white.

"I am not a boy in a meadow," he told the ground. "You will have to do better."

The monster came at the gate.

It was every dark they had walked through, thinned into one hunger. Quarry rust, mine night, lantern snake, snow pit—the faces of it shifted and never settled. Takshak, some whispered without speaking. The King of Serpents, wearing all their losses.

It went for Mani, as the old hungers had. Baby stepped in front. He had no shield. He had a wooden die and a reed bracelet gone to dust and a century in his knees. The monster drove him back—hop, hop, the cruel child's game—and Mani caught him, and Maya was suddenly on the thing's other side with a lantern-glass from Rajatavana, and Taro had a totem-spike from the savannah, and Kael said a number as if numbers could bind a god.

They did not kill it. They could not. They made it remember it was a road, and roads, once named, must go somewhere. Kael shouted the names of all ten stops—Vardhana, Ayaskara, Varshana, Haritavana, Rajatavana, Suvarnagiri, Tamrapatha, Chandrasaila, Nilahima, Sphatika—and the hunger stuttered, split, flowed into the crystal and became a shadow in the facet, coiled and still, not gone, only postponed.

Cutting ice-crystal demanded prayer and patience. Each deposit sat in a vein like a sentence in stone. Taro's hands shook from cold; Mani blew on his fingers between strikes. Maya chose the third deposit's angle without measuring, and the chip that came free was perfect.

The gate-keepers of Sphatika, who were very old and very few, opened the enclosure.

"All who remain," said the eldest, "may play. The dead are counted as present if you carry them."

They set Borin's token on the rim of the board—a river stone Baby had kept from Vardhana, the first stone, the one the snake had sent back. Four played: Baby, Mani, Kael, Maya. Taro witnessed, and wept without hiding it, which was his last invention: a grief that did not become a joke.

The Royal Game at the Crystal Crown was not for a prize. The pieces were ice and amber and a little gold. The die was the same wooden die, the nail-pips almost smooth. They played as the light moved across the

enclosure, a full day, and into a night so clear the stars looked like another board.

Once, the shadow in the crystal pulsed, and the eldest raised a hand. "He watches. He cannot move your pieces. That is the oath he hates."

Baby's last token went home at dawn.

No one cheered. The eldest of Sphatika took their hands, one by one, and pressed them to the crystal until the cold burned.

"The River Oath is sworn," she said. "The ten clans are one walk. Sumbarta is the name of that walk. Do not let the next century think it was a palace."

She looked at the facet where the shadow lay. "Takshak keeps the century he loses. He will test your children's children. Until then, the grass holds."

Outside, the year was turning toward nine hundred. The first roads were still only a rumor of packed earth, a quarry, a causeway, a rope, a lantern, a forge, a totem, a cliff, a cabin, a crown. King Rudravarman had not been born. The Great Canal was a dream no one had dreamed. There were only five living people and one stone on a rim, and a meadow far behind them that had once had a rope for a gate.

Ten cities. Ten wins. One century of mercy bought with walking.

The eldest pressed each forehead to crystal until the cold printed a brief mark—gone by noon, remembered forever. She told them Takshak's bargain in plain words: no flood of serpents on Sumbarta's heartland for a hundred turns of the sun, so long as the record of ten wins survived. Burn the bark, she warned, and the mercy burns with it.

Kael promised on the die. Baby promised on the river stone. Mani promised with her eyes. Maya promised with silence. Taro promised aloud, because that was how he breathed.

Mid-game at the Crown, the shadow in the crystal spoke without a mouth: a hiss like wind through reeds. Only Baby heard it clearly. *Nine*

are won. One board remains. I keep what you drop.

Baby tightened his grip on the die. "We drop nothing," he said, not for Takshak—for himself.

Mani's token and Kael's traded places in a sacrifice no one had taught them; they invented it on the board the way they had invented Sumbarta on the road. Maya blocked the keeper's last serpent-square with a piece of amber from Vardhana, paying the past forward.

Taro witnessed with his hand on Borin's river stone, and the keeper nodded as if the sixth had stood up from the dead to watch.

Stars turned. Tokens moved. The enclosure cooled and warmed with the sun's passage across facets.

When dawn broke, the shadow coiled tighter, smaller—a promise deferred, not a promise broken.

Baby's hand on the crystal felt like the reed bracelet had felt when it was new.



Chapter 11

The Bark Runs Out

~900 BC · Sphatika enclosure

Kael wrote the end the way he had written the beginning.

He wrote: *We were six, and then we were a kingdom, which is not the same as being six, and is the only reason the six mattered.*

The bark was nearly full. Char dust stained his fingers. Smoke from the morning cookfire drifted across the crystal, harmless and ordinary—a miracle after a hundred years of pits and monsters.

Baby Dufaan, whose hair was the color of the reed roofs of his childhood, sat at the enclosure's edge and shook the die once more. It came up one.

Mani laughed. It was a dry sound, but it was hers.

"Deploy," she said. "Or don't. I am done with first steps."

Maya stood with her face in the crystal's light and for a moment looked like a girl in a hidden hamlet, deciding whether a name was a gift or a

knife. Taro set his copper needle on the board and left it, a tool that had finished its work.

Baby put the die in Kael's old hand.

"Write that we were together," he said. "Write it until the bark runs out."

Kael wrote it. He wrote Borin's name again. He wrote the rope. He wrote that Takshak had not been beaten, only bound by rules older than his hunger—a century per perfect walk, a board for every gate, six who must arrive or no game at all.

The crystal held the morning.

Somewhere down the long walk, a child in Vardhana—a child who had never seen them—would one day find a reed bracelet in the mud and think it was only a toy.

It was not only a toy. It was the first city noticing the grass.

And the grass, for one century, had noticed them back.

Mani shouldered an empty pack. Taro took one last look at the shadow in the facet and spat—not in hatred, in habit—and turned toward the downward path.

Five walkers going home, if home still meant reed and river, or if home had become the name they carried.

Kael rolled the bark and tied it with grass cord. The record would outlive his hand. That was enough.

Baby lingered one breath longer at the enclosure's lip. In the crystal he thought he saw a bronze scale, deep as a memory, slide once and still.

Not goodbye. See you in a hundred years.

He followed the others into the grass.

They would not all live to see the canal or the palace or the neon river of futures Kael could not imagine. They had bought one century with ten wins and one death and a wooden die worn smooth—a bargain Takshak

hated because it was fair enough to hold.

Baby looked back once. The crystal crown flashed, then hid itself in morning.

Mani walked beside him without speaking for an hour, then said, "Borin would have wanted the first step down."

"I know," Baby said.

"I still hate five," she said.

"I know."

Taro hummed a canopy bridge-song off-key. Maya joined on the second line, surprising everyone. Kael did not hum. He smiled, which was rarer.

They passed a farmer who asked where they had been. Kael said, "Naming a walk." The farmer nodded as if that were a reasonable answer in this world.

At camp, Baby shook the die one more time in private. Six. He laughed until his eyes watered, then put the die away for the night.

Kael read aloud the first line and the last, comparing them. The rope and the crystal. The same sentence in different weather. Mani fed the fire. Taro sharpened nothing, because nothing needed sharpening anymore.

Maya asked Kael to write one public line for Vardhana's wall, if walls came. He thought, then wrote: *We walked so you could stand still.* She nodded. "They will hate it," she said. "Good," he said. "Hatred remembers."

Baby slept dreaming of boards without monsters—only children, only grass, only a century of breath before the next test woke.

In the morning they would cross Vardhana's meadow again—not as founders, as witnesses to their own legend. Kael would read from bark at the reed gate if anyone gathered. Mani would refuse applause. Taro would fix a lintel. Maya would vanish for an hour and return with nothing to explain. Baby would kneel by the pit Mani had fallen into, now filled with

rain, and leave the carved pip Kesh had given him, a one for the road's beginning.

The die would stay wooden. The oath would stay six, even when they were five.

And Takshak, coiled in crystal far north, would count the years the way walkers count miles—patiently, hungrily, already planning the next board.

The bark was full. The walk continued downward, toward reed smoke and children who would find toys in mud and not know they were treaties.

End.

LUDO SUMBARTA

Continue the legend

The walk echoes in distant centuries. *Ludo Sumbarta: The Oath in Light* (3000–3100 AD) — Tales of Sumbarta.

